would compare Berlin to the testicles of the West. “Every time I want to make the West scream, I squeeze on Berlin.” And squeeze he did. On August 22, Khrushchev made a move in Berlin that many regarded as another step toward a separate treaty with East Germany. The Soviets abolished the office of Soviet commandant of Berlin, creating a situation in which the American, British, and French commandants would be forced to deal directly with the East Germans and thereby provide the regime with a modicum of international legitimacy.[12]

On August 23, Kennedy and his advisers met to discuss the intensification of the Berlin crisis, which, in the words of the president’s national security adviser, McGeorge Bundy, had “warmed up a lot in recent weeks and looks as if it is getting worse.” Kennedy believed that the events in Berlin would lead to a major showdown before the end of the year.[13]

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FOR JOHN KENNEDY, CUBA HAD BEEN OF LOW PRIORITY TILL late August 1962. While Robert Kennedy continued to oversee the administration’s sabotage and psychological warfare measures against the Castro regime, dubbed Operation Mongoose, no one imagined anything even remotely like Operation Anadyr being unleashed on the island.

On August 1, the CIA issued an intelligence estimate suggesting that while the Soviets had provided arms and military equipment to the Cubans, their military capabilities were “essentially defensive.” It was deemed “unlikely that the [Soviet] Bloc will provide Cuba with capability to undertake major independent military operations overseas.” Things began to change rapidly less than a week after the CIA issued its estimate. On August 7, a Spanish-language announcer informed the listeners of his Miami-based Cuban radio program that four thousand Soviet soldiers had landed in Cuba in July. Next day the news was in the *New York Times*. The CIA checked the news originating with Cuban exiles in Florida and found it basically correct.[14]

On August 21 John McCone, the sixty-year-old Eisenhower-era chairman of the Atomic Energy Commission, who had replaced Allen